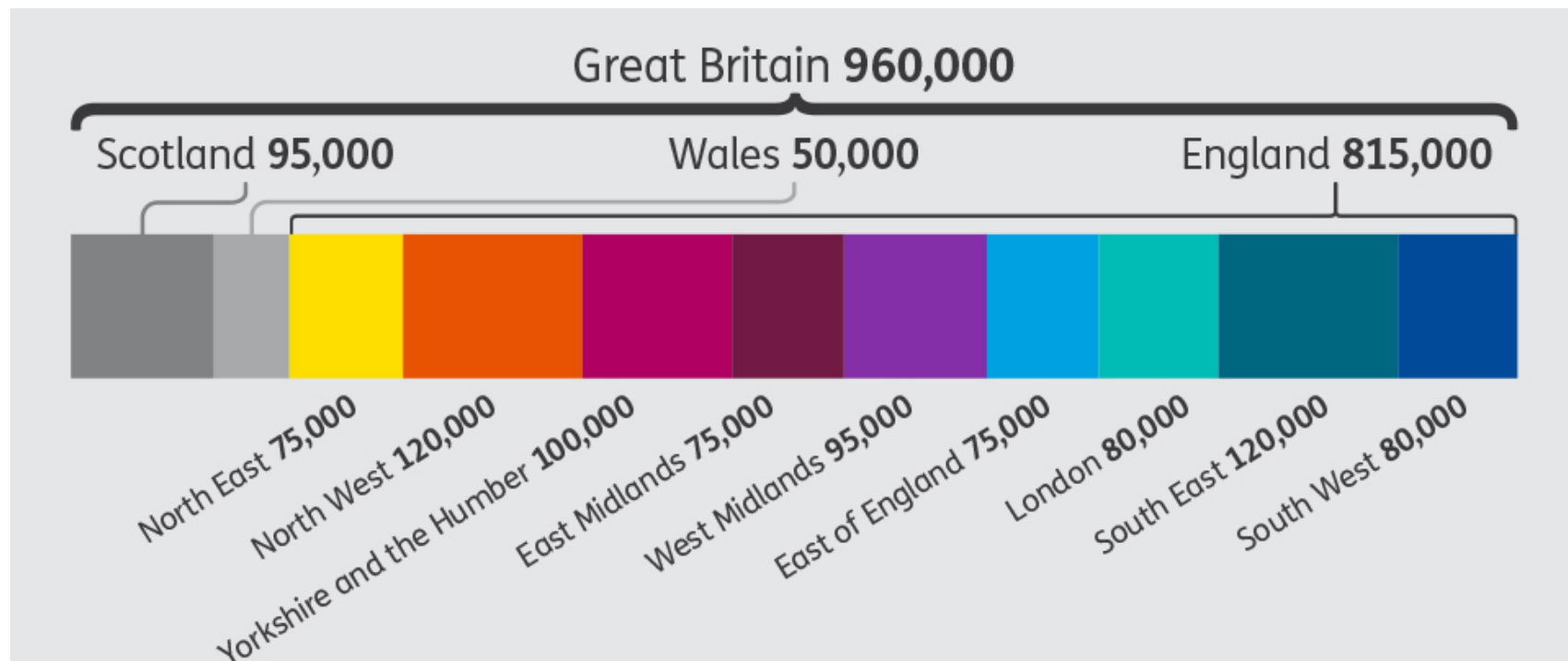




Department
for Work &
Pensions

Sickness absence & the Health and Work Service

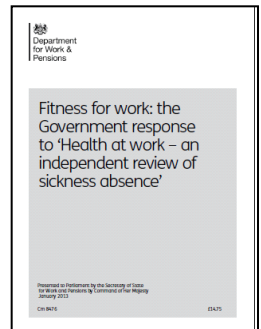
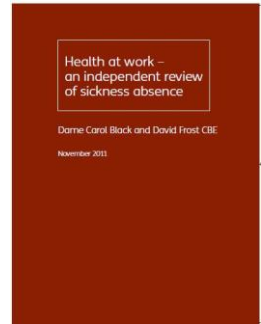
Sickness absence in Great Britain



- 46% of long term absentees (4 weeks+) are over-50 compared with 27% of employee population overall
- 52% of long term absentees are disabled
- Type of employer: 31% large, 27% small & medium, 15% micro

Fitness for Work: the Government response to “Health at Work – an independent review of sickness absence”

- Cost of sickness absence:
 - Economy - £15bn
 - Employers - £9bn
 - Individuals - £4bn
 - Government - £2bn
- A state-funded health and work assessment and advisory service from 2014 [now Health and Work Service]
- Funded through abolition of the Percentage Threshold Scheme
- Access to Universal Jobmatch for those requiring job change
- Retention of tax relief on Employee Assistance Programmes
- Abolition of SSP record-keeping requirements
- Publication of revised fit note guidance
- Budget and Autumn Statement 2013: tax exemption on medical treatments recommended by the Health and Work Service or employer-arranged occupational health services



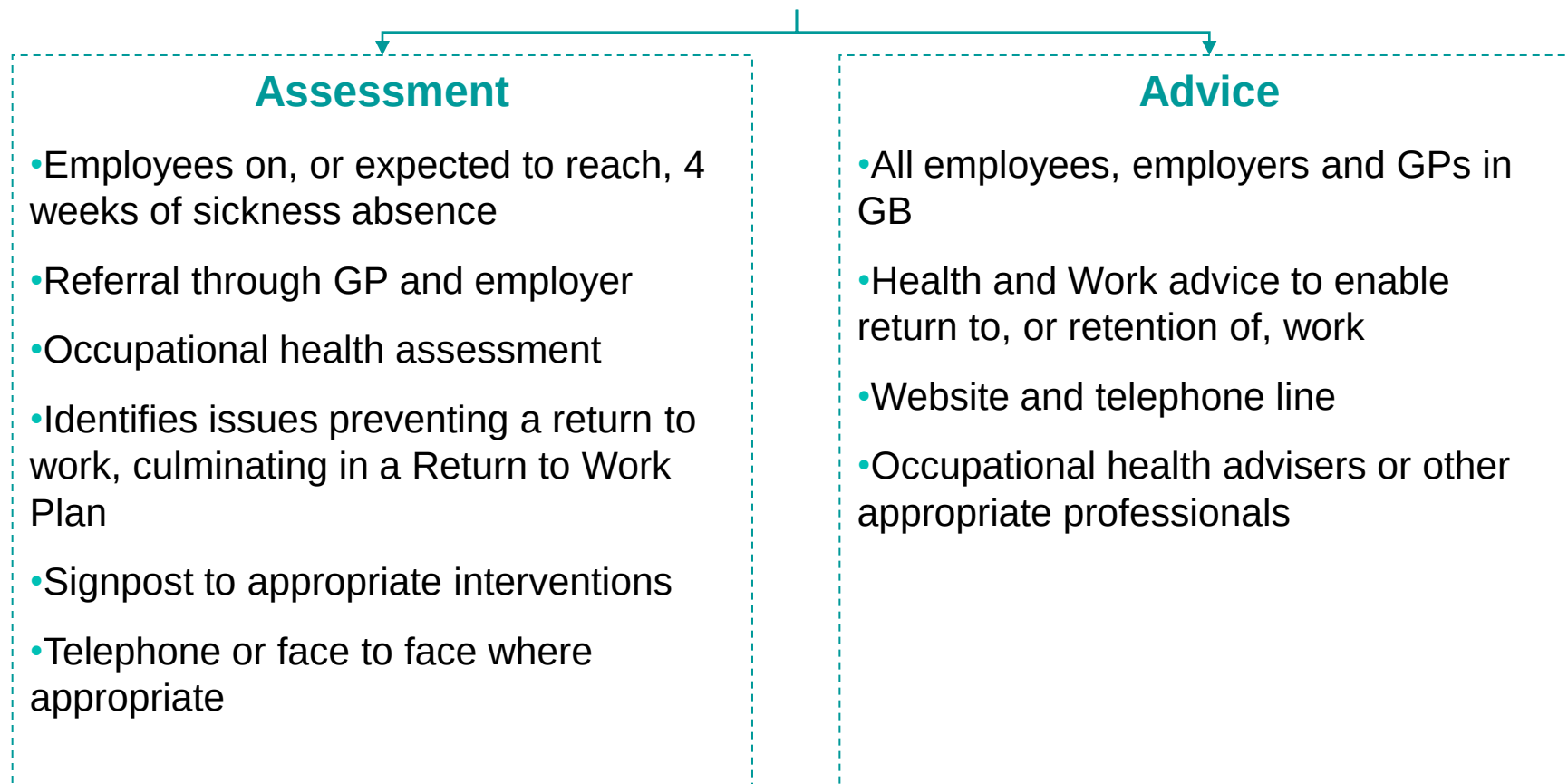
Sickness absence - update

- Published Invitation to Tender for Health and Work Service
- Published analysis on long-term sickness absence
- Published evidence review on telephonic support to support return to work
- Workshop on long-term conditions
- Workshop on mental health (more planned)

Health and Work Service – overview

- 4 – 6 weeks of sickness absence a critical point for not returning to work

Health and Work Service

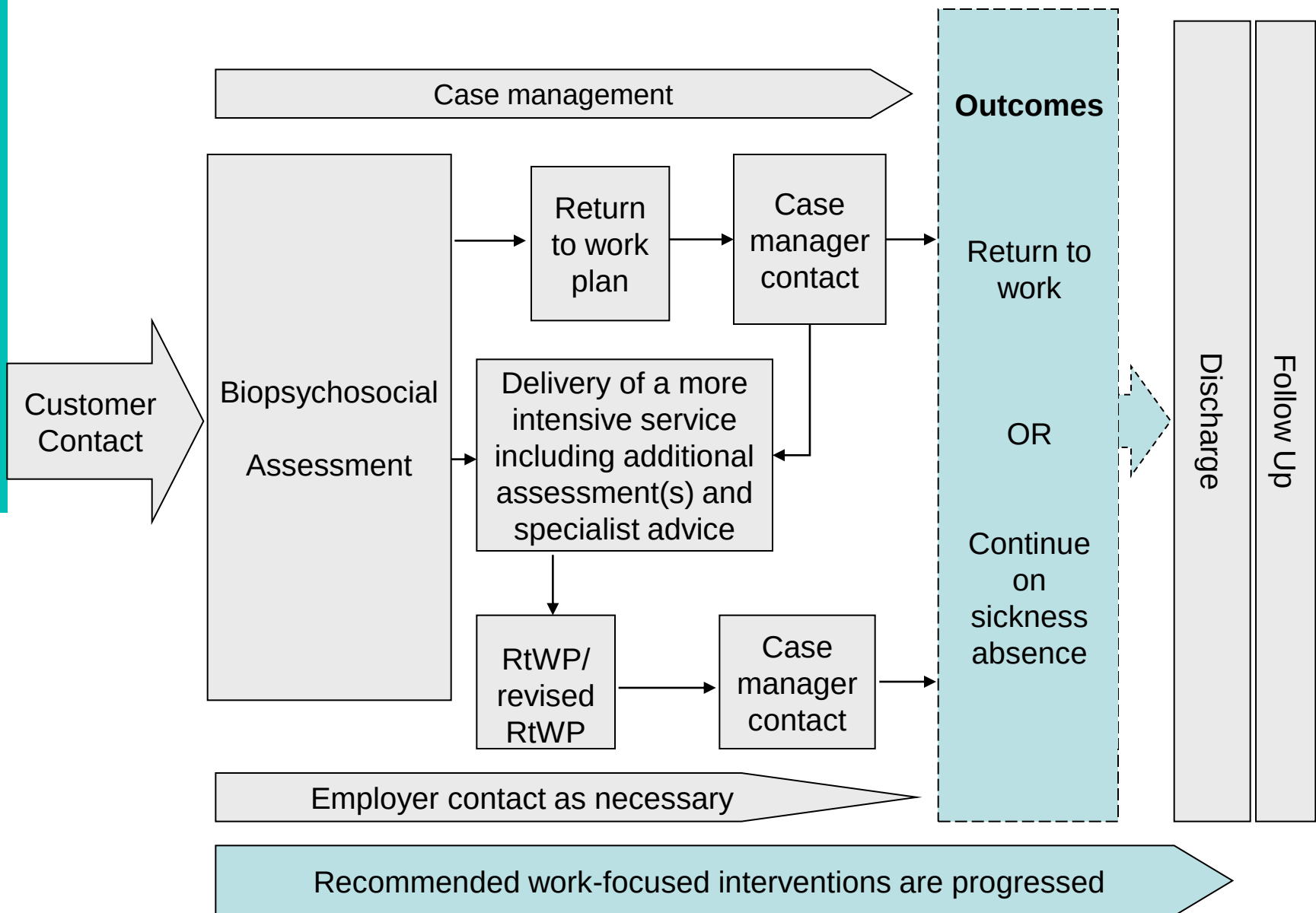


- Invitation to Tender in England and Wales issued on 13th February
- Delivery in Scotland through existing Scottish Government capability

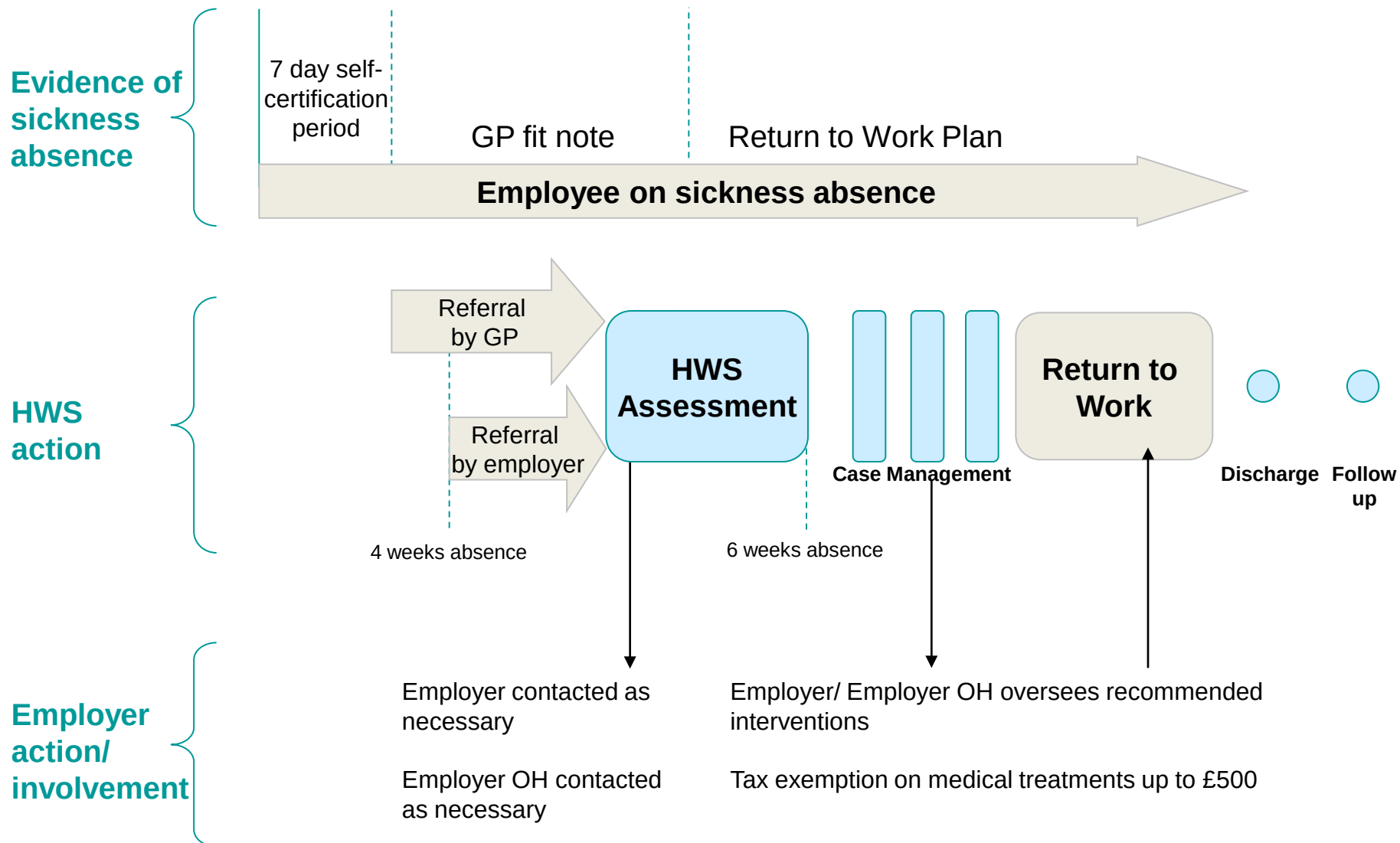
Health and Work Service: Critical Success Factors

- 1. Early intervention that is prompt and rapid**
- 2. Independent and objective advice**
- 3. Quality of advice, assessment, and Return to work plan**
- 4. Easy to use**
- 5. Nationally available, with consistent standards**
- 6. Innovative and flexible**

Health and Work Service – assessment model



Stylised sickness absence journey for an employee receiving SSP and/or contractual sick pay



Health and Work Service – ensuring quality

- Quality of assessment and return to work plan key in ensuring reduction of sickness absence
- Supplier expected to:
 - Use specialist in Occupational Medicine to provide clinical supervision of the Service
 - Use healthcare professionals for delivery of key functions in the Service
 - Ensure health professionals
 - Have the appropriate qualifications;
 - Are registered with the relevant regulatory and/or professional body
 - Have occupational health qualifications and/or relevant experience
 - Meet competencies
 - Achieve SEQOHS accreditation within a year and maintain thereafter
- Quality assessed through independent audit

An specification informed by the needs of employees

‘Services should be focused on the appropriate demographic groups with particular focus on Musculoskeletal (MSK) and Mental Health (MH) conditions..’

‘The supplier must [as part of their assessment model] include specialist advice from MSK and MH professionals when required ‘

‘[Information from the advice service] should focus on the most common reasons for sickness absence at four weeks e.g. MSK and common MH conditions whether short term or chronic and may include specialist advice provided by appropriate professionals.’

Key requirements for MSK specialists:

an ability to deliver MSK self-help advice at the initial assessment; and

- an ability to conduct a physical assessment and give appropriate advice on physiotherapy exercises and other relevant advice independently, without supervision but within the scope of the individuals competence.

Key requirements for MH specialists:

- an ability to conduct a competent MH assessment;
- an ability to deliver MH self-help advice at the initial assessment;
- be knowledgeable of the most relevant techniques and therapies to assist common MH conditions; and
- an ability to give specific advice on relevant MH techniques and therapies independently, without supervision but within the scope of the individual’s competence.

Benefits of the new service

- Benefit to employees through earlier return to work
- Benefit to employers of £65m - £80m per annum
- Benefit to Government of £105m – £225m per annum
- Benefit to economy of £450m - £900m per annum

Health and Work Service: Next Steps

Contract award

- Invitation to Tender published 13th February 2014 to invite interested organisations to apply run the Health and Work Service;
- The successful bidder for England and Wales will be announced in June 2014, with a view to launching the service in autumn 2014.

Any questions?